

Instructor Guide — Lesson 8: Build Social Proof

Metadata

Field	Value
Path	Digital Independence Path → Course 16: Build Your Professional Identity → Lesson 8 (Final Lesson)
Title	Build Social Proof
Format	Live, instructor-led, virtual classroom
Audience	Ages 15–18
Duration	60 minutes
Tools	HTML, CSS, Vercel, Canva, GitHub, Google Docs
Prerequisite	Lesson 7 — live deployed portfolio with bio, brand kit, and 2–3 case studies
Course position	Final lesson of Course 16; leads into Course 17: Skills That Pay

Overview

Students already have a live portfolio. This lesson closes Course 16 by teaching them how to earn and request *honest* social proof — real endorsements from people who actually know their work (teachers, mentors, parents, peers) — and by running a final quality pass on the portfolio itself before it becomes their calling card. The lesson draws a hard, explicit line between ethical social proof and fake or manufactured proof (fabricated testimonials, reviews from strangers, bought reviews, screenshots of fake client praise). Students leave with a polished, verified, live portfolio and a real endorsement-request message ready to send.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Explain what social proof is and why *credible* proof matters more than *quantity* of proof.
2. Distinguish real, ethical social proof (genuine written endorsements, documented outcomes) from fake or manufactured proof.
3. Write a polite, specific endorsement-request message to a teacher, mentor, or parent.
4. Run a full QA/polish pass on their live portfolio (broken links, typos, mobile view, load speed).
5. Complete a final portfolio review using a rubric, and articulate what's next in Course 17.

Prep (before class)

- Confirm every student's Lesson 7 portfolio is still live on Vercel. Open each URL once before class — flag any that 404 or fail to load, and message those students to bring a laptop with their GitHub/Vercel login ready.
- Have your own "instructor demo" portfolio ready with 2–3 *intentionally seeded* problems: one broken link, one typo, one Canva image that overflows on mobile, and one paragraph of text that's too dense. You'll fix these live.
- Prepare a blank endorsement-request email template in Google Docs to co-write with the class.
- Draft one fictional "received endorsement" example (see Talking Points) to project.
- Have the Final Portfolio Review Rubric (below) ready to share as a doc link or screen share.
- Test your screen share of Chrome DevTools mobile view and a network throttle (or PageSpeed Insights / Lighthouse) in advance so the speed demo doesn't eat class time.

Teaching Sequence

1. Hook and framing (5 min)

Ask: "If you were hiring a 16-year-old to build a website, and one portfolio said 'trusted by 50 happy clients!!' with no names, and another said 'My robotics teacher, Ms. Alvarez, wrote: *"He rebuilt our club's sign-up site and it's still running two years later"* — with a link to that site — which one do you believe?" Let students answer. Land the point: **specific, verifiable, real proof beats vague, unverifiable claims every time** — and at your age, having zero testimonials is completely normal and not a weakness.

2. Real vs. fake social proof — talking points (10 min)

Present this contrast directly. Do not soften it — this is the ethical core of the lesson.

Real, ethical social proof looks like: - A short, specific written note from a teacher, coach, mentor, or club advisor who actually saw the work — e.g., "Jordan built our class's study-tracker app for our final project; it's still the best one I've seen from a student." - A parent or family friend's honest note about a real project they watched happen (a small business site, a family tool). - A documented outcome: "This site has been live for 6 months and the robotics club still uses it to publish meeting notes" — verifiable, not vague. - A peer's genuine feedback from a code review or group project. - A link to a real GitHub repo, a real deployed site, a real commit history — proof that *is itself* the evidence, no claim needed.

Fake or manufactured social proof looks like — and is never acceptable: - Writing your own "testimonial" and attributing it to a made-up client or a real person who never said it. - Asking strangers online (forums, social media, review sites) to leave praise for work they never saw. - Testimonial carousels with stock photos and invented names ("Sarah M., CEO"). - Vague inflated claims with no attributable source: "Loved by hundreds!" "5-star rated!" with nothing behind it. - Pressuring or paying someone for a positive quote, or editing a real quote to say more than the person meant.

Say explicitly: **"If you would be embarrassed to have the person you named see what you wrote and attributed to them, don't post it. If a quote didn't happen, in those words, from that real person, it doesn't go**

on your site — ever." This applies for their whole career, not just this class.

3. Live demo — endorsement-request message (15 min)

Screen-share Google Docs. Co-write a message live with student input, thinking aloud:

Subject: Quick favor — would you write a short line about my [project name]?

Hi [Name],

I'm finishing up my coding portfolio for a class, and I wanted to ask if you'd be willing to write a short, honest sentence or two about the [project/robot/site/app] I built [for your class / for the club / with your help]. It doesn't need to be long — just your real impression, good or constructive. I'll only use it if you're comfortable, and I'll show you exactly how it'll appear before I post anything.

No worries at all if you'd rather not — totally understand.

Thanks either way, [Student name]

Call out the components explicitly: it's short, specific (names the actual project), gives an easy out, and promises the person a preview/approval step before anything goes live. Emphasize: **always show the person the final wording before publishing it, and get their okay** — even a real quote can be shortened or reworded in a way the person didn't intend.

Have students open a Google Doc and draft their own version for one real person (teacher, mentor, coach, parent) right now, naming a real project from their portfolio.

4. Live demo — full portfolio polish/QA pass (15 min)

On your seeded demo portfolio, walk through each check live, fixing issues as you go:

- **Broken links:** click every nav link, every case study link, every external link (GitHub, Canva, social). Show the broken one 404-ing, then fix the `href`.
- **Typos:** read the bio and each case study aloud slowly — typos hide in text you've read before. Fix the seeded typo.
- **Mobile view:** open Chrome DevTools → Toggle device toolbar → pick an iPhone/Android preset. Show the image overflowing its container; fix with `max-width: 100%` on the image or container.
- **Load speed basics:** mention image file size as the #1 culprit for slow student portfolios. Show a quick check (browser Network tab load time, or a PageSpeed Insights score) and demonstrate compressing/resizing an oversized Canva export before re-uploading.
- **Contact safety check:** confirm the visible contact method is a school email or a contact form — never a home address or personal phone number.

Then release students to run this same pass on their *own* live site for the remaining time, using the Worksheet checklist.

5. Discussion questions (5 min, can run concurrently with QA work)

- "Why might having zero testimonials right now actually be more trustworthy than having ten generic ones?"
- "If a teacher says yes but asks you to soften a sentence before you post it, what do you do?"
- "What's the difference between a review from a stranger on the internet and an endorsement from your robotics coach?"
- "Your friend says 'just write it yourself and say your mom said it, she won't mind.' What do you say?"

6. Wrap-up and course close (10 min)

Recap Course 16 in one sentence per lesson if time allows, then close with:

"You now have a live, working, honest professional portfolio — built by you, hosted by you, and backed only by things that are actually true. That's rare, and it's worth more than a flashy site full of fake praise. Course 17, Skills That Pay, is where we turn this portfolio into real opportunities — freelancing basics, pricing your work, and finding your first paid or resume-worthy project."

Common Misconceptions

- **"I need lots of testimonials right away."** Correction: one real, specific endorsement beats ten vague ones, and zero is fine at this stage — a strong live portfolio with real projects speaks for itself.
- **"No one will vouch for me, I'm just a student."** Correction: teachers, coaches, and mentors are asked for exactly this kind of note constantly and are almost always willing — the ask in the demo template makes it low-pressure and easy to decline.
- **"It's fine to write it myself if it's basically true."** Correction: if the words weren't the person's own and approved by them, it's fabricated — full stop, regardless of how true the sentiment feels.
- **"More reviews = more credible."** Correction: unverifiable quantity reads as suspicious to anyone experienced; a named, specific, real source is what builds trust.

Student Difficulties & Troubleshooting

Difficulty	What you'll see	Fix
Freezes on who to ask	Blank draft, "I don't know who"	Prompt with a specific list: current teacher, past teacher, coding club advisor, coach, parent, family friend who saw the project
Message reads as demanding	"Write me a testimonial saying my site is amazing"	Model the soft, optional-feeling phrasing again; have them add "no worries if not"
Can't find their own broken links	Skims instead of clicking each one	Require them to literally click every link on the page, one at a time, checked off on the worksheet
Mobile view looks fine to them (desktop-only testing)	Never opened DevTools device toolbar	Pair them with a neighbor's phone or your live demo screen share to check firsthand

Difficulty	What you'll see	Fix
Personal contact info exposed (home address, cell number)	Bio or contact section lists it	Immediately have them replace with school email or a contact form; treat as a required fix, not optional
Wants to invent a testimonial "just as a placeholder"	Suggests using a fake quote "for now"	Reinforce zero-tolerance rule: leave the endorsement section empty or labeled "coming soon" rather than fake

How to Review — Final Portfolio Review Rubric

Criterion	Meets expectations
Live and accessible	Portfolio loads at its Vercel URL with no errors
No broken links	Every internal and external link works
No typos	Bio and case study text is proofread and clean
Mobile-friendly	No overflow, unreadable text, or broken layout on a phone-size screen
Brand consistent	Colors, fonts, and tone match the Lesson 6/7 brand kit throughout
Case studies present	2–3 real case studies are visible and complete
Bio present	A short, current bio is visible and accurate
Contact method present and safe	A school email or contact form is listed — no home address or personal phone number
Social proof (if included) is real	Any endorsement is a genuine, attributed, approved quote — never fabricated

Lesson Close

Confirm every student has: a fixed, live portfolio; a drafted (not necessarily sent) endorsement-request message; and a completed final review checklist. Tell students sending the message is optional homework, not a grade requirement, since it depends on a real person's availability — but encourage them to send it this week while the project is fresh. Preview Course 17: Skills That Pay, starting with turning this exact portfolio into paid or resume-ready opportunities.